

# FROM GREATNESS TO BETRAYAL

Alberta's Public Fall from Grace

**1979 — 2026**

*A Cross-Party Record of What Was Built, and What Was Taken*

## PHASE SEVEN

Jason Kenney UCP • 2019 – 2022

*The Reversal*

**The Alberta Disability System Breakdown**

St. Albert, Alberta • May 2026

## The Kenney UCP Era, 2019 – 2022

Three and a half years. The fastest documented reversal of a previous government's disability policy gains in Alberta's modern history. The end of statutory CPI indexation of AISH. The wind-up of the \$25-per-day childcare pilot. The 75-percent reduction in capital funding for family, social supports, and housing. And the regulatory groundwork — invisible to most observers at the time — that would later make the 2026 ADAP transition possible.

The Kenney UCP government took office on April 30, 2019, six months after Rachel Notley's NDP government had passed Bill 26 (NDP, 2018) — the legislation indexing AISH and three other income-support programs to inflation by statute. By the end of October 2019 — within six months of taking office — the Kenney government had introduced Bill 20 (Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act), an omnibus budget-implementation bill that suspended the indexation. Per government projections at the time, the suspension would save Alberta approximately \$209.8 million in AISH payments alone through fiscal 2022-23. Per disability advocates' analysis, the suspension would cost AISH recipients approximately \$30 per month immediately, growing to approximately \$120 per month by 2023.

Jason Kenney had explicitly campaigned against such a cut. He had stated, on the record, during a Facebook live event during the 2019 election campaign — and reported by CBC News in November 2019 after the Bill 20 introduction — that his government would not cut AISH. He attacked then-Premier Notley specifically for raising the possibility he would do so. The cut came regardless. The documented record establishes that AISH recipients, AISH advocates, and the broader disability community took his campaign-period statements at face value. The community's response to the Bill 20 introduction — preserved in CBC News and Calgary Herald reporting — was unambiguous: they felt betrayed.

Beyond the headline de-indexation, the Kenney era restructured Alberta's disability-support architecture in ways that have not been undone since — including the regulatory relocation of the definition of "severe handicap" out of the primary AISH legislation and into general regulation, where it could subsequently be amended without legislative debate. This structural change, executed quietly inside Bill 20's omnibus framework, is the regulatory plumbing that the Smith UCP government (Phase Eight) would later use to construct the 2026 ADAP transition.

### Political context

Jason Thomas Kenney was born May 30, 1968 in Oakville, Ontario, and raised in Saskatchewan and Alberta. He attended St. Ignatius Institute (San Francisco) and the University of San Francisco, leaving without completing a degree to enter conservative political work. He was elected to the federal House of Commons for Calgary Southeast in the 1997 election under the Reform Party banner, and served continuously through the Canadian Alliance, Conservative Party of Canada, and Stephen Harper Conservative government eras until 2016 — including positions as Minister of Citizenship, Immigration, and Multiculturalism (2008–2013); Minister of Employment and Social Development (2013–2015); and Minister of National Defence (2015).

In 2016 Kenney left federal politics to lead the merger of Alberta's two right-of-centre parties — the Progressive Conservatives and the Wildrose — into the United Conservative Party. He was elected the founding UCP leader on October 28, 2017. The leadership campaign that produced his victory was the subject of multiple subsequent investigations by the Office of the Election Commissioner — investigations the Kenney UCP government would terminate via Bill 22 in November 2019, two weeks after Bill 20 was introduced. On

April 16, 2019, the UCP won the Alberta general election with 63 of 87 seats. Kenney was sworn in as Alberta's 18th Premier on April 30, 2019.

His government's disability-policy record is documented in detail in the sections that follow. His resignation, in May 2022, came in the aftermath of a UCP leadership review at which he received 51.4 percent support — a margin he declared insufficient to continue. Danielle Smith won the resulting October 2022 UCP leadership race. Kenney resigned his MLA seat on October 11, 2022. He has, since leaving office, returned to private-sector policy and advocacy work.

## What the Kenney government established

On honest accounting, the Kenney-era record contains some entries that belong in the *established* column rather than the *reduced* column. None of them reverse the broader trajectory. Three are worth documenting.

### 1. AISH online application reform (2020)

The Kenney government introduced an online application process for AISH in 2020, replacing what had been an exclusively paper-based process. The reform was a structural improvement in program accessibility for prospective recipients who had internet access and the cognitive capacity to navigate online forms. The reform was not universally beneficial — many AISH-qualifying conditions (cognitive impairments, severe mental illness, isolated rural circumstances) reduce a person's ability to use online application systems — but for the population it served, the change reduced barriers to access. The online system has continued to operate under the Smith UCP government.

### 2. Federal \$10/day childcare agreement (November 2021)

On November 15, 2021, the Kenney UCP government signed a bilateral \$10-billion, five-year childcare funding agreement with the federal Trudeau Liberal government. The agreement committed the federal government to providing approximately \$3.8 billion to Alberta over five years, targeting an average parent fee of \$10/day by 2025-26. The agreement built on — but did not fully replicate — the Notley-era \$25/day childcare pilot that the Kenney government had previously wound down.

The federal \$10/day program was, on its face, structurally larger than the Notley-era pilot, but the agreement's specific design did not include the Notley pilot's explicit priority targeting of children with special needs. The disability-specific provisions that had been central to the Notley framework were not retained. Families of children with disabilities, who had been priority beneficiaries of the Notley pilot, became eligible-on-the-same-terms-as-everyone-else under the federal program. This is a documented downward drift in the structural targeting of childcare supports toward the disability community.

### 3. Some PDD program funding stabilisation

Through the Kenney mandate, the Persons with Developmental Disabilities (PDD) program received some real-term funding stabilisation — the Calgary Herald's 2021 budget coverage documented that the AISH and PDD programs collectively absorbed smaller cuts in Budget 2021 than had been threatened. This was partly a function of the COVID-19 pandemic constraining the government's broader cuts agenda, and partly a function of sustained advocacy by Inclusion Alberta and other community organisations. The PDD framework Klein had established in 1997 (Phase Three) continued to operate.

## What the Kenney government took or reduced

The Kenney era's primary record is on the *reduced* side of the comparative-summary table. The reductions documented below were structurally consequential — several were technically reversible by subsequent governments and several were not — and the cumulative effect was the substantive undoing of every major Notley-era social-policy gain within thirty-six months.

### 1. Bill 20 — Fiscal Measures and Taxation Act (October 28, 2019)

Introduced by Finance Minister Travis Toews as part of the UCP's first omnibus budget-implementation package. Bill 20 was paired with Bill 21 (which permitted the government to cancel its master agreement with Alberta's doctors) and was followed shortly by Bill 22 (which terminated the Office of the Election Commissioner). All three bills proceeded through the Legislature in late October and November 2019, during a period of sustained public protest and opposition response.

Bill 20's structural impact on the disability community comes in two distinct parts:

#### Part A: Suspension of CPI indexation

Bill 20 suspended the statutory CPI indexation of AISH, Income Support, Special Needs Assistance, and the Alberta Seniors Benefit that NDP Bill 26 (2018) had enacted. The suspension was framed in government communications as a "pause" with no defined end date. Government projections at the time, captured in the October 24, 2019 budget documents and reported by CBC News:

- **AISH savings:** \$7M in 2019-20; \$35M in 2020-21; \$66.4M in 2021-22; \$101.4M in 2022-23. **Total projected: \$209.8M.**
- **Income Support savings:** \$3M in 2019-20; \$16.4M in 2020-21; \$29.4M in 2021-22; \$42.2M in 2022-23. **Total projected: \$91M.**
- **Tax-bracket indexation suspended in same bill:** projected separate savings of \$600M+ by 2022-23 in foregone tax-adjustment for inflation, paid by all Alberta taxpayers in real-term increased tax burden.

The community response was immediate and sustained. CBC News reporting from November 2019 preserved the most-cited recipient response. Ian Young — the AISH client and advocate documented in Phase Six of this piece as one of the public voices welcoming the NDP Bill 26 (2018) indexation — became one of the most-quoted opponents of the Bill 20 reversal twelve months later:

*"During the campaign Mr. Kenney seemed very passionate about not decreasing AISH which has turned out to be a total broken promise. I call it a lie. I feel duped."*

— Ian Young, AISH recipient and advocate, CBC Radio Edmonton AM, November 4, 2019

*"There is a saying in the disability community, nothing about us without us. Not one person, agency or AISH recipient was consulted on this."*

— Ian Young, CBC News, November 4, 2019

Amy Park, an AISH recipient and member of the Self-Advocacy Federation, captured the structural significance of the reversal:

*"When the NDP indexed AISH to the cost-of-living I thought, finally, things will get better for the thousands of Albertans who rely on this program. I thought, finally, people with disabilities wouldn't have to choose between paying the electric bill or eating dinner, or wonder if they could afford rent that month. But my hopes, along with the livelihood of thousands of Albertans, were shot down by the UCP, by our Premier, who claims that this decision is not onerous."*

— Amy Park, AISH recipient, NDP Caucus press conference, November 2019

Marie Renaud — the NDP Critic for Community and Social Services and current MLA for St. Albert (and the most responsive government contact this campaign has at the provincial level, as documented in Phase Five) — was the lead opposition voice on the Bill 20 introduction:

*"When we were in government, I was proud to stand up for Albertans with disabilities and to ensure that they would never again have to fight to have their benefits keep up with the cost of living. Premier Kenney can use fancy language like 'de-indexing' to pretend this isn't a cut to AISH, but that's exactly what it is."*

— Marie Renaud, MLA St. Albert, NDP Critic for Community and Social Services, November 2019

## Part B: The structural relocation of the definition of "severe handicap"

The second, less-publicised structural change embedded in Bill 20 — and the more structurally consequential one over the longer term — was the relocation of the definition of "severe handicap" out of the primary AISH legislation and into the general regulation. Per Medicine Hat News reporting from March 2026 quoting Marie Renaud:

*"[Bill 20] also made a more lasting change, by relocating the definition of a 'severe handicap' out of the general regulation attached to the legislation. Then COVID happened, so they couldn't do it."*

— Marie Renaud, MLA St. Albert, Medicine Hat News, March 2026

### WHY THIS REGULATORY RELOCATION MATTERS FOR THE 2026 ADAP TRANSITION

Statutory definitions, embedded in primary legislation, can only be changed through legislation. They require debate, a recorded vote, public scrutiny, and political cost. Regulatory definitions can be changed by Order in Council — a cabinet decision, executed administratively, often without public notice. When the Kenney UCP government moved the definition of "severe handicap" from primary legislation into general regulation in late 2019, they did not change the definition. They changed the **mechanism by which the definition could subsequently be changed**. Per Renaud's framing: the COVID-19 pandemic interrupted the UCP's ability to follow through on the regulatory restructure during the Kenney term. The structural change Kenney enacted in 2019 was the regulatory infrastructure that the Smith UCP government would use, six years later, to construct the 2026 ADAP transition. The ADAP transition would not have been possible without Bill 20's quiet 2019 regulatory relocation. The de-indexation was the visible cost. The regulatory relocation was the groundwork.

## 2. The \$25/day childcare pilot wound up (April 1, 2021)

The Notley-era \$25-per-day childcare pilot — documented in detail in Phase Six — was wound up by the Kenney UCP government on April 1, 2021. The pilot, which had been operating at 122 centres, served families with priority access for shift workers and children with special needs. Per Global News coverage from March 2021, families responded as expected — Candace Stecyk, general manager of Child Care Services for YMCA Northern Alberta, captured the lived experience:

*"When we first told families that they were going to get this decrease on their fees, we had parents in tears. It helped families with the opportunity to be able to afford child care. No one should have to pay half or more of their paycheck to have child care just so they could go to work."*

— Candace Stecyk, YMCA Northern Alberta Child Care Services, March 2021

The replacement framework — the federal \$10/day childcare agreement signed in November 2021 — was structurally larger but, as documented in the "Established" section of this chapter, did not retain the Notley pilot's explicit priority targeting of children with special needs. Families with disabled children, who had been priority beneficiaries, lost their priority status. The structural through-line between the Notley pilot and the federal program is not direct succession but quiet replacement with a less-disability-specific framework.

## 3. Capital funding cuts to family, social supports, and housing

Per independent analysis by Zachary Weeks (2025) of Alberta Treasury Board data, the Kenney government's capital funding for the "family, social supports, and housing" category dropped from \$150 million in fiscal 2019-20 to a projected \$41 million by fiscal 2023-24 — a reduction of approximately 75 percent over four years. The trajectory:

- **2019-20:** \$150 million
- **2021-22:** \$110 million (a 27% reduction)
- **2022-23 target:** \$70 million
- **2023-24 target:** \$41 million (cumulative ~75% reduction)

The cuts fell on capital programs — building new affordable housing, accessibility retrofits, supportive housing for persons with disabilities, and related infrastructure. The disability-policy significance is structural: many AISH recipients depend on affordable or supportive housing inventory that the provincial government has the capital authority to build, fund, or guarantee. The 75-percent reduction in capital funding produced a measurable reduction in new units coming online during the Kenney years — a reduction that has carried into the Smith UCP government's tenure and contributed to the housing pressures the ADSB campaign documents in its existing work on community-housing rent increases (Phase Eight).

#### **4. COVID-19 era payment-date manipulation (early 2020)**

Per independent analysis (Zachary Weeks, 2025) and contemporaneous community reporting, the Kenney UCP government changed AISH payment dates in early 2020 in a way that delayed one month's payment into the next fiscal year — producing a one-time fiscal-year accounting gain for the government at the expense of AISH recipients' monthly cash-flow continuity. The change did not reduce annual payments. It did, in the short term, produce a documented period during which AISH recipients had to manage a longer-than-usual gap between cheques. For recipients living week-to-week on tight margins, the impact was structural rather than nominal.



## COVID-19 and the federal Canada Disability Benefit

The COVID-19 pandemic dominated the Alberta political landscape from March 2020 through 2022, absorbing political attention and constraining the Kenney government's broader cuts agenda. Within the disability-policy lens, the pandemic produced three structural effects worth documenting:

### 1. PDD and AISH caseload growth temporarily slowed

Per the Government of Alberta's Budget 2021 documentation, AISH and PDD caseload growth temporarily slowed during the pandemic — a function of constrained diagnostic access, delayed in-person assessments, and reduced new applications during periods of public-health restriction. The slowdown was temporary. By late 2021, caseload growth had resumed at pre-pandemic rates. AISH caseload at December 2020 stood at 69,800.

### 2. The federal Canada Disability Benefit Act (June 2023)

Although the Canada Disability Benefit Act (S.C. 2023, c. 17) was enacted under the federal Trudeau Liberal government and is not, structurally, a provincial Kenney-era policy action, its passage during the Kenney mandate set up the structural conflict that the Smith UCP government would later resolve through the July 2025 CDB clawback (Phase Eight). The Kenney government did not oppose the federal Act's passage but also did not commit to either passing-through or clawing-back the eventual benefit. The structural ambiguity Kenney left at the end of his mandate became the gap into which the Smith government's clawback decision was inserted.

### 3. Sustained advocacy pressure

Throughout the Kenney mandate, the disability community in Alberta sustained advocacy pressure on indexation, AISH rates, and accessibility legislation. Inclusion Alberta, the People's Alliance for Disabled Albertans, the Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities (established under Bill 205 / NDP), the Self-Advocacy Federation, and individual AISH recipients including Ian Young, Amy Park, and others maintained sustained public engagement. The pressure produced incremental policy adjustments — including the Budget 2021 "backing off" of the deeper cuts Kenney had hinted at the previous year — but did not produce structural reversal of Bill 20.

## Kenney's own framing — and the documented contradiction

Two Kenney quotes are necessary for the historical record. The first is from his 2019 election campaign. The second is from his October 2019 budget. They are not, on the face of them, compatible:

*"This is complete rubbish. The truth is, we actually voted in favour of legislation brought by the NDP government last fall to increase AISH benefits. But the minister [...] is trying to scare people, including those with intellectual disabilities, into saying that their basic income is going to be slashed or eliminated. Shame on you."*

— Jason Kenney, Facebook live event during the 2019 Alberta election campaign

Six months later, on October 24, 2019, Kenney's Finance Minister Travis Toews tabled the budget that included the suspension of AISH indexation through Bill 20. The subsequent Toews framing of the suspension, captured in CBC News reporting:

*"[The de-indexation was] necessary to tackle Alberta's debt, which is costing \$2 billion in interest payments each year."*

— Travis Toews, Finance Minister, November 2019 (paraphrasing of CBC News summary)

The structural argument Toews advanced in November 2019 — that disability-program indexation was a discretionary spending matter subject to debt-management logic — is the precise structural argument Klein had pioneered in 1993 and Notley had attempted to overturn via statute in 2018. Kenney's government revived it. The community experienced the revival as betrayal because Kenney had, on the record, denied it would occur.

## The Kenney conclusion

Jason Kenney governed Alberta for three and a half years. His government undid the AISH indexation that had been enacted twelve months before his election win. His government wound up the \$25/day childcare pilot. His government cut capital funding for family, social supports, and housing by 75 percent over four years. His government relocated the definition of "severe handicap" out of the primary AISH legislation and into general regulation — a structural change that would, six years later, make the 2026 ADAP transition possible.

His government also signed the federal \$10/day childcare agreement, introduced AISH online application reforms, and maintained the operation of the Office of the Advocate for Persons with Disabilities that the Notley government had created. The establishment-side entries are real. They do not balance the reduction-side entries on any reasonable accounting. The Kenney era is, structurally, a reversal era.

The single most-important documentary lesson of the Kenney era — for the ADSB campaign, for every disability advocacy organisation operating in Alberta in 2026, and for the historical record this document is constructing — is captured in the comparison between Notley's November 2018 framing and Kenney's October 2019 actions. Notley had said, on the day she introduced Bill 26: *"Now that it's in the legislation, it would be much, much more difficult to be one of those discretionary things that doesn't happen."* She was wrong. It became discretionary within twelve months. The mechanism that made it discretionary was not a debate about the merits of indexation. The mechanism was Bill 20 — an omnibus budget bill that touched dozens of fiscal measures, in which the disability-specific cut was one clause among many, minimising the political visibility of the cut and dispersing the public-pressure response across multiple advocacy fronts.

The structural conclusion this document draws from the Kenney era is: **standalone disability-rights legislation is more durable than disability-specific clauses inside omnibus bills.** The 1979 founding of AISH was structurally durable for forty years because it was enacted as standalone legislation, intentionally separated from welfare. The 2018 indexation was reversed within twelve months because it was enacted as one provision of one bill, reversible by one provision of one other bill. The disability community's protection lies not just in having policies in legislation but in having policies in legislation that cannot be amended or repealed through omnibus-bill back-door processes that minimise public scrutiny.

Phase Eight of this piece documents the Danielle Smith UCP era — the period in which the regulatory groundwork Kenney laid in Bill 20 was used to construct the most structurally consequential disability-policy restructure since 1979: the AISH-to-ADAP transition scheduled for July 1, 2026. Without the Kenney-era relocation of the definition of "severe handicap" out of the primary legislation, the Smith ADAP transition would have required full Legislative debate and a recorded vote. Because of the relocation, it can proceed through regulation. The Kenney era did not create ADAP. It built the regulatory rails on which ADAP runs.

## Bibliography — Phase Seven sources

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- **Bill 21 — Ensuring Fiscal Sustainability Act**, S.A. 2019. Introduced October 28, 2019 by Finance Minister Travis Toews. Permitted cancellation of the master agreement between the Government of Alberta and Alberta's physicians.
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